

Open Source Alternatives for Commonly Used Proprietary Software



Nowadays, a huge range of software is available for the desktop; some come pre-installed with the operating system and the rest can be downloaded from the Internet. Usage of the desktop differs from user to user, and so does the software requirement. This article explores the best open source alternatives for commonly used proprietary software on the desktop.

Before going ahead, we should understand the terms 'proprietary software' and 'open source software'.

In simple words, proprietary software is owned by the company or publisher, and its source code is kept secret. People have to purchase this software to be able to use it. This could be a one-time payment or a recurring cost in case of subscription based models. A person can use the software but cannot view the source code or modify it.

Open source software, as the name suggests, has its source code made available to the user of the software. The user can modify the source code and redistribute it, giving due credits. Usually, all open source software allows the community to participate in development activities, bug-spotting and

fixing, feature enhancement, etc. Many open source software publishers don't charge people for using the software.

Let's explore the different types of proprietary software and their open source alternatives.

Productivity software

The most commonly and frequently used proprietary software is Microsoft Office Suite, which consists of Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Access, Visio, OneNote, Publisher and Project. From the complete list of software in the suite, three draw special attention—Word, Excel and PowerPoint, as these are used by students, beginners and professionals. Most desktop users are familiar with Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint for tasks like letter drafting, report writing, and making some calculations, charts or presentations. Microsoft Office is proprietary software. One needs to purchase it before being able to use it. It comes in many variants and each has a different price, starting from ₹ 4000 and going up to ₹ 30,000 or more. It is available for Windows and Mac platforms.